CYBERSECURITY INTERNSHIP — TASK 2

Phishing Awareness Training

Recognizing, understanding, and defending against phishing emails

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October 2026

INTRODUCTION

What Is Phishing?

Phishing is a form of social engineering in which an attacker impersonates a trusted person, brand, or organization , usually by email - to trick a victim into revealing sensitive information, clicking a malicious link, or taking an action that benefits the attacker.

It remains one of the most common entry points for cyberattacks because it targets people, not just systems — a firewall can't stop someone from being convinced, rushed, or misled.

This training uses two real emails, analyzed with the same forensic checklist, to show exactly what separates a legitimate message from a phishing attempt — not in theory, but in practice.

THE HUMAN ANGLE

Social Engineering Tactics

Urgency

“Your account will be suspended in 24 hours.” Pressure to act fast short-circuits careful thinking.

Authority

Impersonating a bank, employer, or well-known brand so the request feels legitimate.

Fear

Threats of account closure, legal trouble, or financial loss to provoke a panicked click.

Curiosity & reward

Fake prizes, invoices, or “new message” notices designed to be too interesting to ignore.

Trust exploitation

Impersonating a colleague, vendor, or someone the recipient already does business with.

Scarcity

“Limited time” or “only 2 spots left” to rush a decision before it can be verified.

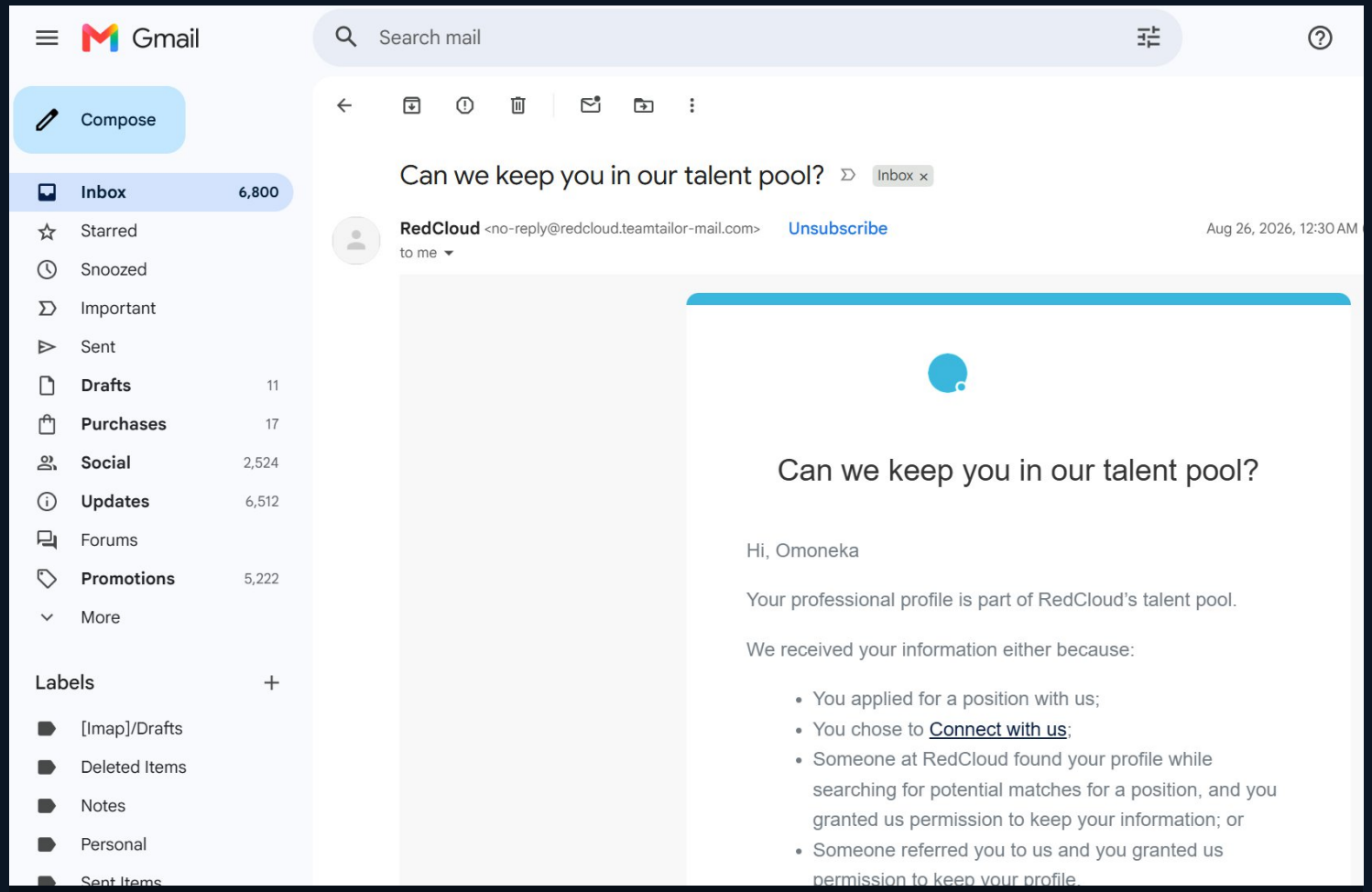
CASE STUDY 1

A Legitimate Email

“Can we keep you in our talent pool?” — a RedCloud recruitment notification sent via Teamtailor

CASE STUDY 1

What the Recipient Saw



CASE STUDY 1

What Made It Legitimate

- Full authentication pass: SPF, DKIM and DMARC all verified the sender.
- The sending server traced back to Amazon SES, a recognized legitimate email service.
- Sender address, reply path, and the link in the email all pointed to the same consistent domain family.
- The link was scanned and came back clean with no malicious indicators.
- The tone was calm and personalized — no threats, no countdown, no demand for immediate action.

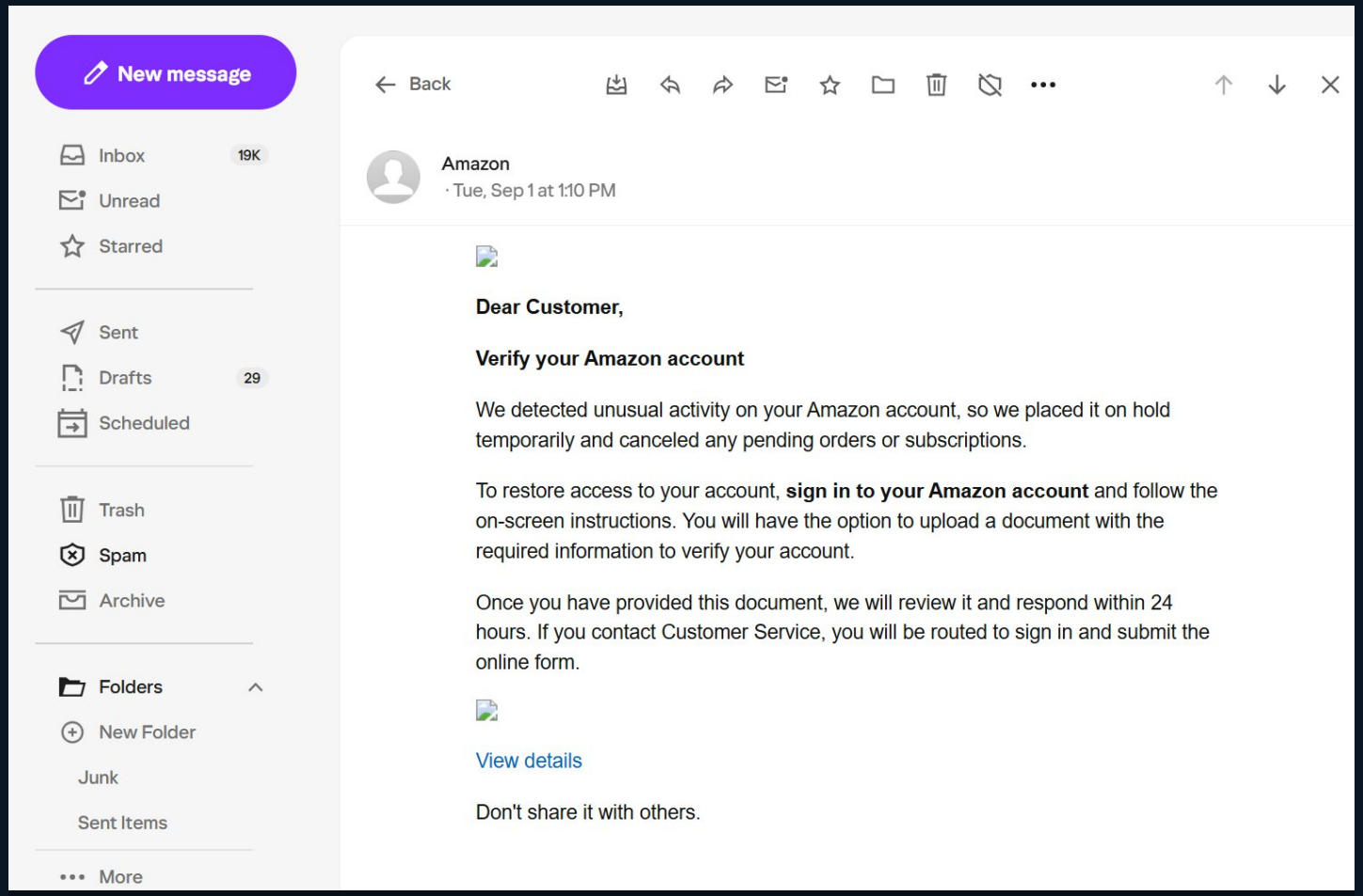
CASE STUDY 2

A Phishing Email

“Account Recovery: Sign-in and Verify your Amazon account” — an impersonation attempt

CASE STUDY 2

What the Recipient Saw



Red Flags

- Generic “Dear Customer” greeting
- Urgency: account “on hold”
- Pressure to sign in immediately
- Vague sender, no personalization

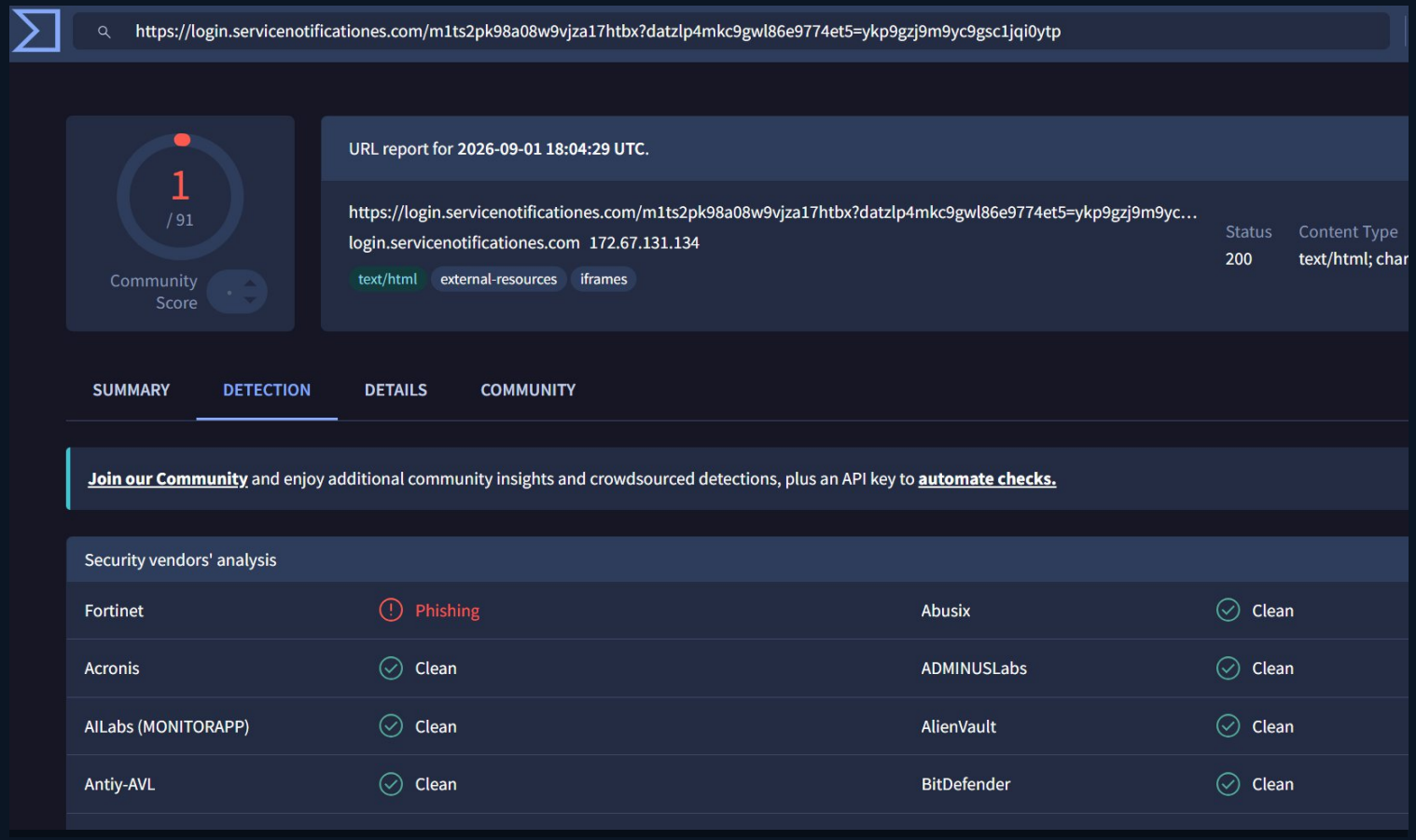
CASE STUDY 2

What Exposed It

- Authentication failed: SPF failed and DMARC failed — it did not meet Amazon's real mail security policy.
- The sender claimed “amazon.com,” but internal message details pointed to a completely unrelated domain.
- The email originated from a home internet connection in another country — nothing like Amazon's real infrastructure.
- The “verify your account” link passed through a trusted-looking redirect and a URL shortener before landing on a fake login page.

CASE STUDY 2 — CONFIRMATION

Final Destination Scan Result



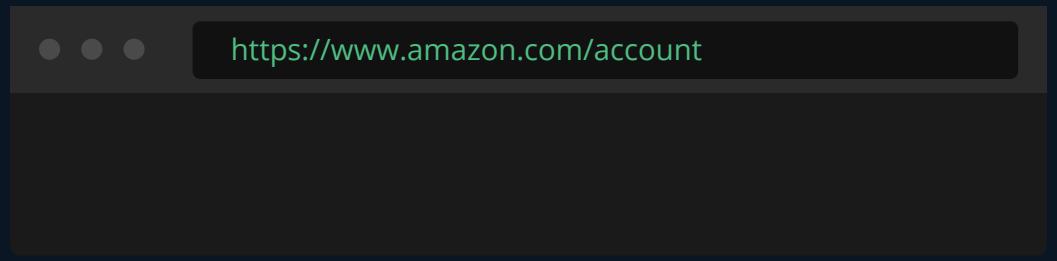
A clean scan of the first link means nothing if the real destination is hidden behind redirects. Tracing the full chain revealed a confirmed phishing page.

BEYOND THE INBOX

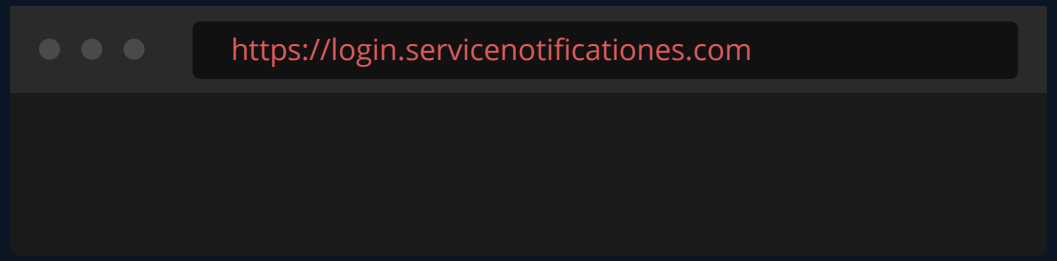
Spotting a Fake Website

A convincing email often leads to an equally convincing fake website. The giveaway is almost always in the address bar, not the page design.

What you expect to see



A typosquat impersonating it



- Read the domain carefully — misspellings, extra words, or unusual endings (.xyz, .top, .info).
- Watch for typosquatting — “arnazon.com,” “amaz0n-login.com,” or a brand name tacked onto an unrelated domain.
- A padlock icon only means the connection is encrypted — it does not mean the site is legitimate.
- When in doubt, don't click through — type the address you already know directly into the browser.

PUTTING IT INTO PRACTICE

Best Practices

Verify independently

Go directly to the official app or website rather than clicking a link in an unexpected email.

Enable MFA

Multi-factor authentication means a stolen password alone isn't enough to grant access.

Never enter credentials via email links

Only log in through a page you navigated to directly.

Report suspicious emails

Flagging to IT/security protects others too, not just you.

Verify through a separate channel

Call the company or person directly if a request feels off.

Practice regularly

Recognizing red flags gets sharper with repetition, not a single read-through.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

Quick Quiz — Part 1

1. Which is a social engineering tactic used in phishing?

Creating a sense of urgency or fear

2. In Case Study 1, what was true?

SPF, DKIM and DMARC all passed on a recognized legitimate provider

3. How did the attacker hide the phishing link's destination?

Chained it through a trusted-looking redirect and a URL shortener

4. What's a sign a website might be fake?

The URL is slightly misspelled or uses an unusual domain ending

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

Quick Quiz — Part 2

5. What should you do if asked to “verify your account” via a link?

Go directly to the official app or website instead of clicking the link

6. Why isn't hovering over a link always enough?

Links can redirect through multiple hops before the final destination

7. Strongest protection if your password is stolen via phishing?

Multi-factor authentication (MFA)

Stay Alert. Verify First.

Thank you — questions and discussion welcome

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